early leaks can provoke adverse reactions to incomplete or out-of-context information, jeopardizing the entire process.

However, an excessive reliance on secrecy can undermine an IO's legitimacy and effectiveness. Transparency is fundamental to ensuring accountability, enabling the public, member states, and stakeholders to evaluate an organization's performance, adherence to norms, and use of resources. When IOs operate behind closed doors, they risk eroding public trust and fostering skepticism about their motives. This perceived opacity can amplify the very grievances populists often exploit, portraying IOs as distant, elitist, and disconnected from the people they serve.

Moreover, a lack of transparency can result in poorer decision making. Public awareness and input often contribute to more informed and robust policies, particularly when IOs address issues with broad societal implications, such as climate change, health crises, or global inequality. NGOs and civil society actors are invaluable partners in these areas, providing local insights and amplifying IO initiatives. For instance, if the WHO were excessively secretive in an effort to collect data on disease transmissions during a health emergency without disrupting states' economic activity, public understanding could suffer, and compliance with health measures might falter.

Secrecy can also create perceptions of hypocrisy, especially when IOs demand transparency from their member states while keeping their own operations opaque. Institutions like the IMF and World Bank often make transparency a condition of their financial assistance, aiming to combat corruption and foster domestic accountability. When IOs fail to hold themselves to the same standard, they risk accusations of double standards and elitism.

In striking a balance, IOs must carefully manage secrecy, ensuring that it facilitates cooperation and protects sensitive negotiations without undermining their transparency, legitimacy, or accountability. A judicious approach can help IOs navigate the challenges of engaging with populist actors while maintaining public trust and organizational integrity.